

Word family: late / later / latest / lately / lateness / latecomer

Base word: late

Comparative: later

Superlative: latest

Related forms: lately, lateness, latecomer

Useful family extensions: late-night, too late, at the latest, sooner or later, better late than never, of late, belated

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

"I saw it about a year ago when I was watching television **late at night** after work."

A full semantic sweep shows that **late** has several important modern meanings, but many grow from one broad concept:

occurring toward or beyond an expected, normal, or final point in time

The major branches are:

1. after the expected/scheduled time;
2. near the end of a period;
3. far into the evening/night;
4. deceased: **the late...**;
5. related forms **later / latest / lately** with meanings learners often confuse.

Meaning in your passage

Here:

late at night

means:

during the later part of the night, usually after the normal evening hours and closer to bedtime/midnight or beyond.

繁體中文：在夜晚較後段的時間；深夜／很晚的時候

Natural translation:

“I was watching television late at night after work.”

「我下班後深夜／很晚的時候正在看電視。」

So here:

late = 在某段時間的較後部分

It does **not** mean the speaker was “late for an appointment.”

1. late = after the expected/scheduled time (時間／約定) — 遲到的; 遲的

This is one of the central meanings.

Practice 1

“I was **late** for work.”

「我上班遲到了。」

Practice 2

“The train was twenty minutes **late**.”

「火車晚點了二十分鐘。」

late = 比原本預定、正常或應該發生的時間更遲

2. be late for + event/appointment/work (活動／約會／工作) —遲到

A very important grammar pattern.

Practice 3

“She was **late for the meeting.**”

「她開會遲到了。」

Practice 4

“Don’t be **late for class.**”

「上課不要遲到。」

be late for + event = 在應該到達／開始的時間之後才到

3. **late + payment/report/application** (付款／報告／申請) — 遲交的; 逾期的

The thing itself happens after a deadline.

Practice 5

“The company charged a fee for **late payment.**”

「公司對逾期付款收取費用。」

Practice 6

“Late applications will not be accepted.”

「逾期提交的申請不會獲接納。」

late = 在規定期限之後才完成、提交或支付的

4. **late = near the end of a period** (時段／年代／人生階段) — 後期的; 接近末段的

This is the core idea in your original sentence.

Practice 7

“We arrived in the **late afternoon**.”

「我們在下午較後時段／傍晚前到達。」

Practice 8

“The company grew rapidly in the **late 1990s**.”

「公司在**1990** 年代後期快速增長。」

late + time period = 位於某段時間的後半／接近結束部分

Common:

- late afternoon = 下午較後段
 - late evening = 晚上較後段
 - late summer = 夏末／夏季後期
 - late 1990s = 1990 年代後期
 - late career = 職業生涯後期
-

5. late at night (夜晚後段) — 深夜；很晚的時候

This is your exact construction.

Practice 9 — Original

“I was watching television **late at night**.”

「我深夜／很晚的時候正在看電視。」

Practice 10

“The streets are quiet **late at night**.”

「街道到了深夜很安靜。」

Practice 11

“I try not to drink coffee **late at night**.”

「我盡量不在深夜／臨睡前很晚的時候喝咖啡。」

late at night = 夜晚已進入較後時段，通常比一般晚間活動時間更晚

6. **late** = happening toward the end of someone's life/career (人生／事業) — 晚年的；後期的

Practice 12

“He became a painter **late in life**.”

「他到了晚年才成為畫家。」

Practice 13

“Her **late-career** work became more experimental.”

「她職業生涯後期的作品變得更具實驗性。」

late in life/career = 在人生或職業生涯接近後期的階段

7. **the late + person** (已故人士) — 已故的；已去世的

This is a genuinely distinct meaning.

Practice 14

“The award was named after the **late professor**.”

「這個獎項以那位已故教授命名。」

Practice 15

“Her **late husband** was a doctor.”

「她已故的丈夫是一名醫生。」

the late + person = 該人已經去世

Important:

late husband

does **not** mean:

「經常遲到的丈夫」✗

It means:

已故丈夫.

Context and grammar are crucial.

8. **late-night + noun** (活動／節目／食物) — 深夜的; 夜深時進行的

A very useful compound extension.

Practice 16

“I watched a **late-night television show**.”

「我看了一個深夜電視節目。」

Practice 17

“We went out for a **late-night snack**.”

「我們出去吃了點宵夜／深夜小食。」

late-night + noun = 在夜晚很後段進行、出現或供應的

Note the hyphen before a noun:

a **late-night** programme

but:

“We stayed up **late at night**.”

9. too late = beyond the time when action is still possible/useful — 太遲；為時已晚

A major fixed expression.

Practice 18

“It’s **too late** to change the booking.”

「現在更改預訂已經太遲／為時已晚。」

Practice 19

“By the time I noticed the problem, it was **too late**.”

「等我發現問題時，已經來不及了。」

too late = 已超過仍能有效採取行動或改變結果的時間點

10. late = delayed beyond the normal stage (發展／發生) — 較遲出現的；延後的

Practice 20

“The flowers are **late** this year.”

「今年花開得比正常時間遲。」

Practice 21

“The rainy season arrived **late**.”

「雨季今年來得較遲。」

late = 某件通常在特定時間／階段發生的事，比正常時間更晚發生

11. **later** = after the present/mentioned time — 後來；之後；稍後

This is one of the most important family forms.

Practice 22

“I bought the headphones a few weeks **later**.”

「幾個星期後，我買了那副耳機。」

Practice 23

“I’ll call you **later**.”

「我遲些／稍後打給你。」

later = 在目前或前面所提時間之後的某個時間

12. **later + noun** (較後的時間／階段) — 較後的；後來的

Practice 24

“We can discuss that at a **later stage**.”

「我們可以在較後階段再討論。」

Practice 25

“His **later work** was more successful.”

「他後期的作品更加成功。」

later + noun = 在另一時間／階段之後出現的

13. **later** = comparative: more late / at a more advanced time — 更遲

Practice 26

“The second train leaves **later**.”

「第二班火車開得更遲。」

Practice 27

“I usually go to bed **later** on weekends.”

「週末我通常睡得更晚。」

later = 與另一時間相比，發生在更後的時間點

14. **latest** = most recent/newest (消息／產品／版本) — 最新的；最近的

This is extremely important because **latest** does **not normally mean simply** “most late.”

Practice 28

“Have you seen the company’s **latest product**?”

「你看過公司的最新產品嗎？」

Practice 29

“What is the **latest news**?”

「有甚麼最新消息？」

latest = 在一連串事物中最近出現、發布或發生的；最新的

Common:

- latest news = 最新消息
 - latest version = 最新版本
 - latest model = 最新型號
 - latest research = 最新研究
-

15. the latest = the newest information/trend/product — 最新消息／最 新款／最新潮流

Practice 30

“Have you heard **the latest**?”

「你聽到最新消息了嗎？」

Practice 31

“She always buys **the latest** in technology.”

「她總是購買科技方面的最新產品。」

the latest = 最新出現的消息、產品、潮流或發展

16. at the latest = no later than a specified time — 最遲；最晚不得超過

A very important fixed expression.

Practice 32

“Please arrive by six **at the latest**.”

「請最遲六點到達。」

Practice 33

“The report must be submitted by Friday **at the latest**.”

「報告最遲必須在星期五提交。」

at the latest = 這是容許的最晚時間，不可再遲

Compare:

the latest version = 最新版本

by Friday at the latest = 最遲星期五

Completely different application.

17. lately = recently / during the recent past — 最近；近來

This is one of the biggest learner traps.

Practice 34

“I’ve been very busy **lately**.”

「我最近／近來很忙。」

Practice 35

“Have you used the headphones much **lately**?”

「你最近常用這副耳機嗎？」

lately = 在距離現在不久的一段時間內；最近

It does **not** mean 「遲地」.

Critical distinction: late vs lately

late

= after expected time / near end of a period

“I arrived late.”

「我遲到了。」

lately

= recently

“I’ve been tired lately.”

「我最近很累。」

So:

I arrived lately. ❌ if you mean “我遲到了”

That would not normally mean the same thing.

18. lateness = state of being late — 遲到；延遲；時間過晚

Practice 36

“He apologized for his **lateness**.”

「他為自己的遲到道歉。」

Practice 37

“The **lateness** of the hour made everyone tired.”

「時間已經很晚，令大家都很累。」

lateness = 某人／某事比預定時間遲，或時間已進入很後階段的狀態

Two contextual uses:

- punctuality → 遲到
 - time itself → 時間過晚
-

19. **latecomer** = person who arrives late — 遲到者

A useful family extension.

Practice 38

“Latecomers will not be admitted after the performance begins.”

「表演開始後，遲到者將不得進場。」

Practice 39

“A few **latecomers** entered during the first ten minutes.”

「最初十分鐘內有幾名遲到的人進場。」

latecomer = 比指定／預定時間更遲到達的人

20. **latecomer** = person/organization that joins a field relatively late — 後來加入者；後進者

A figurative extension.

Practice 40

“The company was a **latecomer** to the smartphone market.”

「這家公司是智能電話市場的後來加入者／後進者。」

Practice 41

“He was a **latecomer** to social media.”

「他很晚才開始使用社交媒體，是個較遲加入的人。」

latecomer = 比其他人較遲進入某個活動、行業、科技或潮流的人／機構

21. of late = recently (較正式) — 最近；近來

A useful formal/literary expression.

Practice 42

“Sales have improved **of late**.”

「銷售額近來有所改善。」

Practice 43

“She has seemed tired **of late**.”

「她最近看起來有點累。」

of late = **recently** / **lately**; 近來

Register: more formal/literary than **lately**.

22. sooner or later = eventually — 遲早；早晚有一天

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 44

“Sooner or later, the battery will need replacing.”

「遲早電池都需要更換。」

Practice 45

“You’ll have to make a decision **sooner or later**.”

「你早晚都需要作出決定。」

sooner or later = 雖然不知道確切時間，但事情最終一定／很可能會發生

23. better late than never — 遲做總比不做好

A very common proverb/fixed expression.

Practice 46

“He finally apologized—**better late than never**.”

「他終於道歉了——遲做總比不做好。」

Practice 47

“She started learning English at fifty. Better late than never.”

「她五十歲才開始學英語。遲開始總比永遠不開始好。」

better late than never = 即使做得較遲，也比完全不做更好

24. at this late stage = 到這麼後期；事到如今

A very useful abstract extension.

Practice 48

“It would be difficult to change the design **at this late stage**.”

「到了這麼後期／事到如今，要更改設計會很困難。」

Practice 49

“At this late stage, cancellation would be expensive.”

「到了這個後期階段，取消安排的成本會很高。」

late stage = 一個過程已經進行到很後期，改變空間通常較少

25. belated = happening later than appropriate/expected — 遲來的；姍姍來遲的

This is a **family-extension note**, not another grammatical form of **late**.

Practice 50

“Please accept my **belated birthday wishes**.”

「請接受我遲來的生日祝福。」

Practice 51

“He offered a **belated apology**.”

「他作出了遲來的道歉。」

belated = 本應較早出現，但延遲至較後才發生的

Common:

- belated birthday wishes
- belated apology
- belated recognition

This is exactly the kind of useful extension our Family Sweep should catch.

Important distinction: late vs later

late

= after expected time / near end of period

“I arrived late.”

「我遲到了。」

later

= after another time / more late

“I arrived later than she did.”

「我比她更遲到。」

or:

“I’ll call later.”

「我遲些再打。」

So **later** has both:

- comparative meaning;
 - “afterwards” meaning.
-

Important distinction: later vs latest

later

= 後來／更遲

“a later version”

「較後的版本」

latest

= 最新

“the latest version”

「最新版本」

This difference is crucial.

later version

= 後來出現的一個版本, 不一定是最新的

latest version

= 截至目前最新的一個版本

Important distinction: latest vs last

These are often confused.

latest

= newest / most recent

“the latest model”

「最新型號」

last

can mean:

- previous one;
- final one.

“last year”

「去年」

“the last chapter”

「最後一章」

So:

latest news = 最新消息

last news ❌ normally not the same

Important distinction: late vs lately

Worth repeating:

“She arrived **late**.”

= 她遲到了。

“She has been busy **lately**.”

= 她最近很忙。

Lately = **recently**, not “in a late manner.”

Important distinction: late vs delayed

late

describes the result relative to time.

“The train is late.”

「火車晚點。」

delayed

emphasizes that something caused it to happen later.

“The train was delayed by bad weather.”

「火車因惡劣天氣延誤。」

A train may be **late** because it was **delayed**.

Important distinction: late vs overdue

late

= after expected/due time.

overdue

= should already have happened/been returned/paid and is now past the deadline.

“a late payment”

「遲交付款」

“an overdue payment”

「已逾期、應付而未付的款項」

Overdue often emphasizes that the obligation remains outstanding.

Important distinction: late vs deceased

When speaking directly about someone who has died:

“the late Professor Wong”

is a conventional respectful adjective.

But in ordinary sentences:

“Professor Wong is late”

means:

黃教授遲到了

—not dead.

Word position completely changes interpretation.

Important distinction: late at night vs lately at night

Correct:

late at night = 深夜

Not:

lately at night ❌

because **lately** means **recently**, not “at a late hour.”

Important word-position patterns

After verb:

“I arrived **late**.”

Before noun:

“a **late** payment”

Time-period modifier:

“the **late** afternoon”

Deceased person:

“the **late** professor”

The surrounding noun determines the sense.

Family-extension sweep

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- **late** — **punctuality** = 遲到／晚點
- **late payment/application** = 逾期
- **late** — **period** = 時段／年代後期
- **late at night** = 深夜
- **late in life/career** = 晚年／後期
- **the late + person** = 已故的
- **late-night** = 深夜的
- **too late** = 太遲／來不及
- **later** — **afterwards** = 之後／稍後
- **later** — **comparative** = 更遲
- **latest** — **newest** = 最新
- **the latest** = 最新消息／最新產品
- **at the latest** = 最遲
- **lately** = 最近／近來
- **lateness** = 遲到／時間過晚
- **latecomer** — **punctuality** = 遲到者
- **latecomer** — **figurative** = 後來加入者／後進者
- **of late** = 近來

- **sooner or later** = 遲早
- **better late than never** = 遲做總比不做好
- **late stage** = 後期階段
- **belated** = 遲來的

There are some rarer historical uses of **late** meaning “former/recently holding a position,” but in modern learner English they are much less important and can easily be confused with **late** = **deceased**. I would therefore exclude them from the core set unless a specific text requires them.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
late — punctuality	比預定、正常或應該發生的時間更遲
be late for	在某活動／工作／課堂應到時間之後才到達
late payment/application	超過規定截止日期才付款／提交的
late — period	位於某段時間的後半或接近結束部分
late at night	夜晚已進入較後時段；深夜／很晚
late in life/career	位於人生或職業生涯的較後階段
the late + person	該人已經去世；已故的
late-night + noun	在夜晚很後段進行、出現或供應的
too late	已超過仍可有效行動或改變結果的時間點
later — afterwards	在目前或前文所提時間之後
later — comparative	與另一時間相比發生得更遲
latest	在一連串事物中最近出現、發布或發生的；最新的
the latest	最新消息、產品、潮流或發展
at the latest	容許的最晚時間；不得再遲

lately	距離現在不久的一段時間內;最近／近來
lateness	比預定時間遲, 或時間已進入較後階段的狀態
latecomer — literal	比指定／預定時間更遲到達的人
latecomer — figurative	比其他人較遲進入某個活動、行業或潮流的人／機構
of late	較正式地表示「近來／最近」
sooner or later	雖不知道確切時間, 但最終會／可能會發生;遲早
better late than never	即使做得較遲, 也比完全不做更好
belated	本應較早發生, 但延遲到後來才出現的;遲來的

For your original sentence

“I saw it about a year ago when I was watching television **late at night** after work.”

The exact meaning is:

late = 夜晚已進入比較後段, 時間比一般晚間活動時段更晚

So:

late at night

= 「深夜／很晚的時候」

Natural full translation:

「我大約一年前看到那則廣告, 當時我下班後深夜正在看電視。」

And the biggest learner traps in this family are:

late = 遲／晚

later = 後來／更遲

latest = 最新

lately = 最近

They look closely related, but they are absolutely **not interchangeable**.